



Investigation report

Rejected take-off and runway overrun, Tarlton Springs - NTSB-style
probable cause report

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INVESTIGATION WORKFLOW SUITE

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Executive summary

What happened

On 18/06/2026, Saltbush Air SB512, a 50-seat twin-turboprop registered VH-SBQ, began its take-off from runway 09 at Tarlton Springs Aerodrome in full darkness. On board were 44 passengers, 2 flight crew and 1 cabin crew.

At 07:30:31 UTC the first officer called two kangaroos crossing onto the runway from the northern side. One second later the captain rejected the take-off at 118 kt, 6 kt above V1. At 07:30:33 the No. 2 propeller and right main gear struck the animals. Reverse thrust was then available on No. 1 only. The aircraft left the end of the runway at about 21 kt at 07:30:51. It stopped 62 m into the 90 m runway end safety area (RESA), upright on the extended centreline and 28 m short of ungraded terrain. No evacuation was commanded, and the passengers disembarked by the forward airstair.

There were no serious injuries. One cabin crew member reported bruising during the disembarkation, and two kangaroos were killed. The aircraft was substantially damaged:

- three No. 2 propeller blades were damaged beyond limits
- the right main gear doors were distorted
- both right main tyres deflated through the fuse plugs
- the lower right fuselage was punctured

The aerodrome was closed for 4 hours 20 minutes.

What the investigation found

The runway overrun resulted from a take-off rejected 6 kt above V1 after two kangaroos moved onto the sealed surface of runway 09. This very likely began a stop the runway could not accommodate. It was combined with a propeller strike that removed No. 2 reverse thrust and reduced the achieved deceleration approximately 15% below the scheduled accelerate-stop performance. The scheduled margin was 67 m. With 695 m of sealed runway remaining at the reject, the aircraft needed 757 m to stop.

The presence of the kangaroos on the runway very likely contributed. They very likely entered through a 140 m failure in the northern perimeter fence, which the aerodrome operator had recorded in 04/2023 and deferred as unfunded at three budget rounds.

The roll began 5 minutes after the end of civil twilight, inside the period in which the aerodrome's own log recorded most of its kangaroo movement. This likely contributed.

No runway inspection was requested. The operator required one only at aerodromes listed after a reported strike, so Tarlton Springs was never listed. This very likely contributed. Because no document prompted either crew member to consider an inspection, the omission likely contributed.

The evening service was approved as a schedule change without reopening a route risk assessment that restricted the aerodrome to daylight operations. This likely contributed, although a review might have addressed only lighting and fuel.

Under AS-139, the aerodrome was too small to require a documented wildlife plan. This likely contributed, but the finding rests on argument rather than direct evidence.

Rejected take-off training covered aircraft system failures below V1 only, and this likely contributed to the decision. The captain also stated that he knew the rule and departed from it deliberately.

The prompt braking response very likely kept the overrun within the RESA.

The investigation also examined factors that were not found to have contributed:

- Partially unserviceable floor proximity emergency lighting very likely increased risk in any evacuation.
- The crew's long duty likely increased risk.
- A tailwind and a No. 2 engine power loss were both ruled out.
- Whether edge lighting intensity reduced detection of the animals could not be determined.

What can be done

A runway inspection control that can be armed only by a strike cannot prevent the first one. On 26/06/2026 the operator listed Tarlton Springs by temporary revision TR-2026-04. The investigation recommended that the operator list aerodromes on wildlife exposure rather than on reported strikes. It also recommended a route risk assessment trigger for any aerodrome first operated into after last light.

On 25/06/2026 the aerodrome operator installed a temporary electric wire and funded fence replacement for 09/2026.

No safety action had been recorded on the following safety issues:

- the wildlife plan threshold
- the change approval process
- rejected take-off training for runway obstructions
- floor proximity lighting monitoring

The lesson for operators and aerodromes is that wildlife knowledge held locally must reach the crews who depart there.

Factual information

History of the flight

On 18/06/2026, Saltbush Air SB512, a 50-seat twin-turboprop registered VH-SBQ, was scheduled from Tarlton Springs to Sydney. It was the crew's fifth sector and the last of the day, added that morning when the rostered crew reported unfit. On board were 44 passengers, 2 flight crew and 1 cabin crew. The first officer was pilot flying.

The doors closed at 07:16 UTC (17:16 local), 40 minutes behind schedule, in darkness. The tower was rostered to close at 18:00 local. [NOT ESTABLISHED: time of last light and end of civil twilight at Tarlton Springs on 18/06/2026]

At 07:29:10 the tower cleared SB512 for take-off on runway 09, wind 090 at 6 kt. Neither the tower nor the crew raised a runway inspection. No wildlife transmission was made on the tower channel in the preceding 90 minutes.

Power was set at 07:30:02. The captain called "Eighty knots" at 07:30:15 and "V one" at 07:30:29, at 112 kt. At 07:30:31 the first officer called "Roos - roos, roos, on the left, they're on the -". The occurrence notification recorded two kangaroos moving onto the runway from the northern side, past the 1,100 m point. The first officer estimated the range at first sight as about 200 m, possibly less.

At 07:30:32 the captain called "Stopping. I have control." and rejected the take-off at 118 kt, 3 seconds and 6 kt past V1, with 695 m of sealed runway remaining. About one second later the right main landing gear and the No. 2 propeller struck the animals. The occurrence notification recorded both animals struck. The captain's safety report described at least one. At 07:30:34 the first officer said the aircraft had taken one on the propeller.

At 07:30:36 the captain called "Reverse - number two's not coming. Max brakes, max brakes." Reverse was obtained on the No. 1 engine only. At 07:30:47 the captain said "We're not stopping on it."

The aircraft left the end of runway 09 at about 21 kt at 07:30:51. It stopped at 07:30:57, upright on the extended centreline, 62 m into the 90 m runway end safety area (RESA), with the nose wheel in graded gravel.

Seeing no fire or abnormal indications, the captain set the parking brake and decided not to evacuate. Both engines were shut down at 07:31:26. At 07:31:34 he instructed the cabin to remain seated, then told the tower the aircraft had run off the end of runway 09 and asked for the aerodrome emergency plan. The tower activated it at 07:32:10 and dispatched a vehicle. There was no fire.

Passengers disembarked by the forward airstair, heard operating at 07:34:40. No evacuation was commanded and no slides were deployed. The main cabin lights were on throughout. The occurrence notification gave the disembarkation as 4 minutes 8 seconds after the aircraft stopped. The timeline gave it as 07:34:40 to 07:38:48.

Injuries to persons

There were no serious injuries. One cabin crew member reported bruising during the disembarkation. Two kangaroos were killed.

Damage to aircraft

The aircraft was substantially damaged:

- three No. 2 propeller blades damaged beyond limits
- No. 2 engine shock-load inspection required
- right main gear doors distorted
- both right main tyres deflated through the fuse plugs
- lower right fuselage punctured

Personnel information

Captain

The captain held 8,410 hours total, 2,140 on type, and had been in command for 3 years 1 month. He joined the operator in March 2011 and held one previous turboprop type rating. Crew records gave his last cyclic simulator check as 11/03/2026, all items satisfactory. His interview background gave February 2026. His last line check, on 02/12/2025, was satisfactory. He had no prior occurrence history and two rest days before the occurrence.

First officer

The first officer held 1,655 hours total, 405 on type. Crew records showed 14 months with the operator. Her interview background gave 14 months in role and 17 months with the operator, joining in April 2025. Her last cyclic simulator check, on 28/04/2026, was satisfactory. Her interview background recorded a line check in May 2026. She had two previous sectors into Tarlton Springs, both in daylight, on 09/01/2026 and 17/02/2026, and one rest day before the occurrence.

Duty

The crew duty record gave sign-on as 06:30 local. The captain's interview background gave 05:10 local. The occurrence was at 17:30 local, 11 hours 00 minutes into a planned duty of 12 hours 05 minutes ending at 18:35 local. The maximum for five sectors with that sign-on was 12 hours 30 minutes. Duty and rest in the preceding 7 days were within company limits, with no variations.

Both pilots described themselves as tired at interview. The captain said he would have declined a sixth sector. The first officer described a normal five-sector day with a proper mid-duty break in Sydney.

Both flight crew returned negative post-occurrence drug and alcohol tests.

Aircraft information

The take-off was planned at 20,800 kg, flap 10, dry runway 09, 5 kt headwind component. [NOT ESTABLISHED: aircraft type designation, maintenance status and deferred defects before the flight]

During the disembarkation, the first officer saw unlit sections of the cabin floor proximity strip aft, with emergency lighting armed and ceiling lights on. She told the engineer the next morning. A functional check was carried out on 24/06/2026. [NOT ESTABLISHED: result of the functional check of the floor proximity lighting]

Meteorological information

The recorded headwind component was 4 to 6 kt throughout the roll, consistent with the tower wind and the 07:00 UTC routine observation. No tailwind component was recorded. The runway was dry.

Recorded data

The FDR and CVR were removed at 12:40 UTC on 18/06/2026 and read out by the operator's flight data section, which issued report FDA-2026-0417-R1 on 24/06/2026.

Until the power levers were retarded at 07:30:32, both engines were at take-off torque (98.4% and 98.5%), with no exceedance, caution or warning. Fuel flow, ITT and propeller RPM were within normal scatter.

The power levers reached flight idle within 0.6 seconds of the reject. Maximum braking (2,940 psi) was established at 07:30:34, 2 seconds after the decision, against an operator fleet mean of 3.2 seconds. Anti-skid was active on all four wheels.

The impact at 07:30:33 produced lateral and vertical acceleration spikes of 0.31 g right and 1.48 g. No. 2 propeller RPM decayed from 07:30:33 and the No. 2 reverse interlock did not make.

Mean deceleration from 07:30:34 to 07:30:44 was 2.6 m/s², approximately 15% below the certified accelerate-stop value, which assumes symmetric reverse. It fell to 1.9 m/s² in the gravel.

Groundspeed reconstruction placed the aircraft 1,152 m along runway 09 at the reject. The stopping distance from 118 kt was 757 m.

At 07:32:35 the first officer told the captain the animals "came out of the dark on the left of the strip, crossed the centreline", and that she had them for about "two seconds. Maybe less." At 07:32:47 the captain said "I never had them. I was heads-in on the engine page after V one."

Aerodrome information

The day's only runway inspection, at 21:35 UTC on 17/06/2026 (07:35 local on 18/06/2026) before the first arrival, recorded the movement area clear. No further inspection was made or requested.

The aircraft stopped 28 m short of the end of the RESA, beyond which the terrain is ungraded.

The aerodrome's paper wildlife sighting log held 46 entries from 01/2025 to 06/2026:

- 41 recorded kangaroos on or adjacent to the movement area
- 38 of those 41 were timed between one hour before and two hours after last light
- eleven recorded animals on the sealed surface of runway 09/27

The log was not reported to any operator. The aerodrome reporting officer confirmed no airline had ever asked for it. [NOT ESTABLISHED: condition and repair history of the perimeter fence, beyond the recorded deferral of its repair for three budget cycles]

The pilots' accounts of the runway edge lighting differed. The captain described a corridor of light with darkness either side, and could not tell whether this was why he did not see the animals. The first officer described the lighting as normal, her only comparison being two daylight landings. She saw the animals clearly once they were on the sealed surface. [NOT ESTABLISHED: measured runway edge lighting intensity setting at the time]

Organisational and management information

Under Part A 8.14, the operator requested a runway inspection before the first departure after last light only at aerodromes listed in Appendix 8A. The listing criterion was a previous strike. Tarlton Springs was not listed. The Safety Department reviewed Appendix 8A on 03/03/2025. [NOT ESTABLISHED: content of the 03/03/2025 review]

The evening Tarlton Springs service was approved as a schedule change without reopening the route risk assessment. The captain received no briefing on its introduction.

A documented aerodrome wildlife plan was required only above a size threshold that Tarlton Springs does not meet. [NOT ESTABLISHED: the instrument setting the threshold and the threshold value]

The operator's rejected take-off training covered aircraft system failures below V1 only. The captain recalled no recurrent training scenario other than engine failures in twenty years.

The first officer's preflight material (flight plan, charts, ERSA entry and company aerodrome brief page) did not mention animals. The captain had seen kangaroos on the strip at Tarlton Springs four or five times and mentioned it to ground staff, but never filed a report.

Tests and research

The aircraft was inspected from 19/06/2026 to 21/06/2026.

- The No. 2 propeller had leading edge deformation and one blade tip separation. Animal tissue was recovered from two blade roots.
- Borescope inspection found no pre-existing engine damage and no evidence of a power anomaly before the impact.
- The right main gear structure was within limits.
- Brake energy absorbed was 84% of the certified maximum. There was no brake fire or hydraulic leak. The anti-skid system tested serviceable.
- The fuselage punctures were consistent with propeller debris.

The runway survey recovered carcasses at 1,188 m and 1,221 m from the runway 09 threshold. It found continuous tyre marks from 1,160 m to the runway end, and a nose wheel rut to 62 m beyond it on the extended centreline.

Additional information

The aerodrome was closed for 4 hours 20 minutes and the aircraft was quarantined at Tarlton Springs. The Head of Flying Operations suspended the evening Tarlton Springs service pending the outcome of the investigation.

Analysis

External Influences

Documented wildlife plan required only above a size threshold the aerodrome does not meet

Aerodrome Standard AS-139 section 10.4 sets two levels of obligation. Under 10.4.1, the operator of every certified aerodrome "must take reasonable measures to reduce the risk to aircraft operations presented by wildlife". Under 10.4.2, a documented wildlife hazard management plan is required only where the aerodrome "is used by aeroplanes having a maximum take-off weight exceeding 27,000 kg, or serves more than 350,000 passenger movements in a calendar year". Under 10.4.3, where 10.4.2 does not apply, the measures "need not be documented".

Tarlton Springs met neither limb of 10.4.2. Its heaviest scheduled aeroplane was 22,900 kg, and it handled 61,400 passenger movements in 2025. The aerodrome held no wildlife hazard management plan, no hazard assessment and no dispersal programme. Apart from the single daily inspection before the first arrival under Aerodrome Manual 6.3, nothing documented its wildlife measures. The aerodrome was not in breach of the standard. The certified aerodrome register and the aerodrome operator's own compliance file both confirmed this position, and the documents are not in dispute. It is virtually certain that the threshold applied and that the aerodrome held no documented plan.

The investigation's interest in the threshold lies in what the aerodrome already knew. Its wildlife sighting log for 01/2025 to 06/2026 contained 46 entries, and 41 of them recorded kangaroos on or adjacent to the movement area. Of those 41 entries:

- 38 were timed between one hour before and two hours after last light
- eleven recorded animals on the sealed surface of runway 09/27.

The log was a paper register kept in the aerodrome office. It was not passed to any operator, and the aerodrome reporting officer confirmed that no airline had ever asked for it.

The aerodrome also knew that the northern fence had failed. The council's works register showed the following:

- In 04/2023, the section between the 700 m and 1,300 m runway markers was recorded as failed, with animals observed passing through it.
- Its replacement was deferred as unfunded at the 2023, 2024 and 2025 budget rounds.
- In 02/2026, the same section was recorded as deteriorating further.
- A site inspection on 23/06/2026 found a continuous 140 m section of fence with an animal pad through it at the 1,050 m mark.

The knowledge of where and when kangaroos came onto the runway therefore existed. It never left the aerodrome office, and the defect it pointed to was never funded.

The case for influence rests on what a documented plan would have provided. Such a plan is the mechanism that would have connected the sighting log to the operators using the aerodrome. It is also the mechanism that would have placed the fence on a funded programme rather than an unfunded works register. A documented plan brings an owner and an audit trail. Each of the other controls that failed in this occurrence failed for want of exactly those things.

The case against influence was also considered. Section 10.4.1 still obliged the aerodrome operator to take reasonable measures. A documented plan is not the only way to repair a fence or to pass a sighting log to an airline. The council's three deferrals were budget decisions, and no evidence

showed that a documented plan would have been funded any better than the works item was. A plan is paper, and the fence required money.

The investigation weighed these arguments and did not dismiss the case against. It found that the absence of an owner and an audit trail was the common feature of the controls that did not work, and that the threshold in 10.4.2 is what removed both from an aerodrome of this size. However, the investigation could not show that a documented plan would have secured funding for the fence or prompted an operator to ask for the log. For that reason, the influence of the threshold is put at likely. That is a lower degree of confidence than the other contributing factors in this occurrence carry, and the finding should be read with that in mind.

The deferral of the fence repair and the inspection requirement that applied only at listed aerodromes were both found to have very likely contributed. Each is argued in its own subsection under Organisational Influences and Risk Controls. They are referred to here only as the paths through which the absence of a documented plan reached the occurrence.

The threshold in AS-139 10.4.2 left Tarlton Springs without a documented wildlife hazard management plan, and this likely contributed to the occurrence by leaving the aerodrome's knowledge of kangaroo activity and its failed northern fence without an owner or an audit trail.

Organisational Influences

Perimeter fence repair deferred for three budget cycles

The aerodrome operator had known of the breach in the northern perimeter fence since 04/2023. Works register item WR-221, raised that month, recorded the following on the northern boundary between the 700 m and 1,300 m runway markers:

- four displaced panels
- strained wire
- animals observed passing through.

It recommended replacement at an estimated \$41,000. The item was deferred at the 2023, 2024 and 2025 budget rounds. Each deferral recorded it as unfunded and for review at the next cycle. Item WR-263, raised in 02/2026, recorded the same section as deteriorating further. These are the aerodrome operator's own entries. The defect and its repeated deferral virtually certainly existed.

The site inspection on 23/06/2026 found a continuous 140 m section of the northern fence with the bottom two wires separated from the posts. It also found a clear animal pad through the fence at the 1,050 m mark (Figure 1). That inspection took place five days after the occurrence. The register entries made before the occurrence describe the same section as failed and worsening, which is consistent with the condition found.



Figure 1: The northern perimeter fence at the 1,050 m mark, photographed on the site visit: the fallen section and the animal pad through it. Site inspection photograph SV-2026-0417-07, northern boundary at the 1,050 m runway marker, taken 23/06/2026

The breach lay on the animals' path. The first officer called the animals on the left of the aircraft. They moved onto runway 09 from the northern side past the 1,100 m point. The carcasses were recovered at 1,188 m and 1,221 m from the runway 09 threshold. Both positions are beyond the pad at 1,050 m and on the same side of the runway. A fence in the condition found does not exclude kangaroos.

The aerodrome's wildlife sighting log for 01/2025 to 06/2026 shows the exposure behind the breach. It held 46 entries. Of these, 41 recorded kangaroos on or adjacent to the movement area, and 38 of those 41 fell between one hour before and two hours after last light. Eleven entries recorded animals on the sealed surface of runway 09/27. The log was a paper register held in the aerodrome office. It was not reported to any operator, and no airline had asked for it. The aerodrome therefore held evidence that animals were using the breach and reaching the runway. The repair still went unfunded for three cycles.

The deferral occurred under a regulatory framework that did not require this aerodrome to document its wildlife measures. That framework is discussed under External Influences.

The repeated deferral of the northern perimeter fence repair very likely provided the route by which the two kangaroos entered the runway strip and moved onto the sealed surface.

Evening service approved as a schedule change, route risk assessment not reopened

RRA-041 issue 3, dated 11/2022, was the current route risk assessment for Tarlton Springs. It assessed runway length and accelerate-stop margin, the single runway with no lighting redundancy, the absence of an alternate within 200 nm at night, limited engineering support, and summer heat and density altitude. It imposed the restriction "daylight operations only pending review of night lighting and diversion fuel policy".

CMR-2025-118 was approved by the Head of Flying Operations on 22/05/2025. It added an evening rotation six days per week from 14/07/2025. This was the first scheduled company operation into Tarlton Springs after last light. The change record gave its assessment as "schedule change only" and stated "No new hazard identified". Against "Route risk assessment review required" it recorded "No". It did not refer to the daylight restriction. RRA-041 was not reopened and no issue 4 exists. The Safety Department's records show no involvement beyond receipt of the approved record. These matters are documentary and nothing contradicts them. The approval and the absence of review virtually certainly occurred.

The change record tested whether the elements of the operation were new: the aerodrome, the aircraft type, crew qualifications and engineering support. It did not test whether the existing route assessment still held for the operation proposed. Under that framing, a night operation passed as a schedule change, even though the operator's current assessment for the route expressly restricted operations to daylight.

The approver has left the company and could not be interviewed. Why the change was assessed in this way was therefore not established. This report draws no conclusion about the approver's reasoning.

A review of RRA-041 against a night operation would have reached the aerodrome's wildlife exposure. It would also have reached the aerodrome's absence from Appendix 8A in the same pass. The evidence on the other side was also considered. The restriction named night lighting and diversion fuel policy only, and a review might have been confined to those two matters. The approver's account of what was considered was not available. For these reasons the influence of this factor is assessed as likely and no higher. The design of the Appendix 8A listing, and the absence of a runway inspection on the night, are argued in the analysis of risk controls.

Approving the evening service as a schedule change without reopening RRA-041 likely left Tarlton Springs outside the operator's runway inspection requirement when night operations began.

Risk Controls

Runway inspection required only at listed aerodromes, and the listing criterion is a strike

The operator had a defence aimed at this hazard. Part A 8.14.2 states that at an aerodrome listed in Appendix 8A, "the pilot in command shall request a runway inspection from the aerodrome operator prior to the first departure after last light, and shall not commence the take-off roll until the result of that inspection has been passed." At other aerodromes, 8.14.3 states that "no specific action is required."

The control was sound. Its trigger was not. Appendix 8A lists an aerodrome "where a wildlife strike involving a company aircraft has been reported at that aerodrome within the preceding 24 months." No other evidence admits an aerodrome to the list, and nothing in Part A asks a crew to report a sighting. An aerodrome could therefore be listed only after the event the inspection exists to prevent.

Tarlton Springs had never been listed. Its wildlife sighting log for 01/2025 to 06/2026 held 46 entries. Of these, 41 recorded kangaroos on or adjacent to the movement area. Of those 41, 38

were timed between one hour before and two hours after last light, and eleven recorded animals on the sealed surface of runway 09/27. The log was a paper register held in the aerodrome office. It was not reported to any operator, and no airline had asked for it. None of it could reach Appendix 8A, because none of it was a strike. The list was last reviewed on 03/03/2025, four months before the evening service began. The approval of that service without reopening the route risk assessment is discussed under Organisational Influences. The size threshold for a documented wildlife plan is discussed under External Influences.

Had the requirement applied, an inspection would have been requested, and the roll could not have started until its result was passed. Aerodrome staff disperse animals when they find them. The aerodrome's only runway inspection that day was carried out before the first scheduled arrival.

There is a limit on this argument. An inspection completed some minutes before departure does not guarantee a clear runway when the roll begins. Animals could have entered after it. That possibility lowers the confidence in the link but does not break it. The absence of a request on the night is discussed under Individual Actions.

The Appendix 8A listing criterion, which only a reported strike could meet, very likely contributed to no runway inspection being requested before the first departure after last light.

Rejected take-off training covers aircraft system failures below V1 only

Part B 4.6.4 states: "At or above V1 the take-off shall be continued." Section 4.6 gives no guidance on an obstruction seen on the runway at any speed. It also does not amplify 4.6.4 for a case in which continuing is itself hazardous. TRG-SYL-07 module 4 has four scripted scenarios: engine failure at 90 kt, engine fire at 100 kt, configuration warning at 85 kt, and engine failure at V1 plus 5 kt, continued. All four are aircraft system events. In the five cycles held on file, no crew had been presented with an external obstruction, and 214 crew completed the module in the current cycle alone. Both flight crew stated independently that every stop or go scenario they had been given was an engine event below V1. Scenario records earlier than five cycles were not available. It was therefore extremely likely, rather than certain, that the gap extended across the fleet's training history.

The first officer called "Roos - roos, roos, on the left" at 07:30:31, at 116 kt. The captain called "Stopping. I have control." at 07:30:32, at 118 kt, 3 seconds after V1. The captain later stated, "I never had them." The decision was made on the call alone, in about one second.

There were two readings of the training gap's part in that decision. On the first, the captain met the question for the first time with no briefed or practised frame to draw on, which training exists to prevent. On the second, the captain stated that he knew the rule and departed from it deliberately because he judged the alternative worse. Obstruction training would not have changed what he knew. On that reading the gap is a matter for the fleet, not a cause of this reject.

The investigation accepted the first reading at a lower confidence than certainty. A decision made unrehearsed within a second is not the same decision as one made against a practised frame. The second reading was not dismissed. It also stands. This explains the decision and does not excuse it. The decision itself is discussed under Individual Actions.

Rejected take-off training and Part B guidance that addressed only aircraft system events, with nothing on an obstruction at or above V1, likely contributed to the take-off being rejected 6 kt above V1.

Cabin floor proximity emergency lighting partially unserviceable

While walking back through the cabin during the disembarkation, the first officer noticed sections of the aisle floor strip unlit. A functional check on 24/06/2026 found two of the six floor proximity

escape path segments on the left side aft of row 16 dark. The system was armed and on battery power at the time. The fault was traced to a failed ballast common to both segments.

It was unlikely that the defect had any bearing on the overrun or its outcome. No evacuation was commanded. The main cabin lights were on throughout. Passengers left by the forward airstair without urgency, 4 minutes 8 seconds after the aircraft stopped.

The defect still matters. The pre-flight emergency lighting test on this type illuminates the ceiling lights and exit signs. It neither illuminates nor monitors the floor segments, so the crew and line engineers could not detect the fault. The last dedicated functional test was 11 months before the occurrence, within the 24-month programme interval. The same ballast is fitted across the type, so the state of the fleet's floor proximity lighting is unknown. In a night evacuation, with smoke or a fire indication, two dark segments in the aft cabin could degrade the escape path when it was most needed.

A latent defect in the floor proximity escape path lighting, which no routine check could detect, very likely increased risk to occupants in any evacuation of the type.

Local Conditions

Departure in the hour after last light, the peak of kangaroo movement

It is extremely likely that the departure was made in full darkness, inside the period of greatest kangaroo movement at the aerodrome. The take-off roll began at 17:30 local. That was 32 minutes after sunset and 5 minutes after the end of civil twilight. The moon would not rise until 22:41, and it was 14% illuminated. There was no natural ambient light on the strip and no town lighting within sight.

The aerodrome's sighting log placed 38 of its 41 kangaroo entries between one hour before and two hours after last light. The log is a paper register, and its completeness could not be verified. That limits confidence in the exact proportion, but not in the pattern the log shows.

The light condition bore directly on detection. The investigator's site visit at the same time of day on 23/06/2026 confirmed that the unlit graded strip either side of the sealed surface cannot be seen from the centreline. The animals were not seen until they were on the lit surface. The first officer's account on the CVR after the stop was consistent with this: "They came out of the dark on the left of the strip, crossed the centreline."

On its own, a departure after last light is unremarkable. Its significance is that it placed the aircraft in the window where the aerodrome's own history showed the hazard was concentrated, and where nothing off the seal could be seen. That is the condition a runway inspection before the first departure after last light is meant to address. The absence of that inspection is analysed under Risk Controls.

It is likely that departing in the hour after last light contributed to two kangaroos entering the runway strip and moving onto the sealed surface without being seen until they were on the lit runway.

Runway edge lighting intensity reduced the crew's ability to detect the animals

The investigation examined whether the intensity of the runway edge lighting reduced the crew's ability to see the animals. The matter could not be settled. The evidence left it about as likely as not.

Some evidence supported the proposition:

- The captain recalled the lighting as brighter than he would have wanted. He described a corridor of light with everything outside it black, and said that anything off the seal could not be seen coming.
- A photometric check on 25/06/2026 found four northern edge lights between the 900 m and 1,200 m markers at 118% to 131% of the nominal intensity for stage 3. This was the section the animals crossed. The remaining lights were within tolerance.
- The aerodrome operator's maintenance programme checks lamp serviceability but does not measure intensity.

The intensity deviation is established. The step from that reading to a reduced ability to see an animal on the runway 09 surface is an inference.

Other evidence weighed against it. The first officer was the crew member who saw the animals. She described the lighting as normal and said she saw them clearly once they were on the sealed surface, at about 200 m. She also said that, with only two daylight sectors into the aerodrome for comparison, she was not well placed to judge whether the lighting was unusual. The captain's account does not establish a lighting effect either. He was heads-in on the engine page after V1, which is where the procedure placed him. As he said on the CVR, "I never had them. I was heads-in on the engine page after V one." His non-detection is explained without reference to the lighting.

The matter could not be resolved for four reasons:

- The only measurement was taken seven days after the occurrence.
- Nothing recorded what the lights were doing on the night.
- The two crew accounts of the lighting disagree.
- Nothing establishes a link between an edge light at 131% of nominal and the detection of an object on the runway.

Settling it would need a record of edge light intensity on the night and evidence of how that intensity affects detection of an object on the sealed surface. Neither was available.

Whether the edge lighting intensity reduced the crew's ability to detect the animals remains unresolved, and no conclusion is drawn from it.

Take-off commenced with a tailwind above limits

A tailwind was ruled out as very unlikely to have existed. The aerodrome observations at 06:30, 07:00 and 08:00 UTC gave a headwind component of 5 to 7 kt on runway 09. The recorded aircraft data gave a headwind component of 4 to 6 kt throughout the roll. The crew's performance entry used a 5 kt headwind.

Fifth sector, 11 hours into duty, 40 minutes behind schedule

It is virtually certain that the crew were on the fifth sector of a duty that began at 06:30 local. That sector had been added that morning when the rostered crew reported unfit. The occurrence was 11 hours 00 minutes into a duty planned at 12 hours 05 minutes, against a limit of 12 hours 30 minutes. The aircraft departed 40 minutes behind schedule. Both crew described themselves in interview as tired but not struggling.

A late sector at this point in a long day is where degraded decision making would be expected. The recorded data did not show it:

- The power levers reached flight idle 0.6 seconds after the decision.
- Maximum braking followed 2 seconds after the decision, at the fast end of the operator's fleet distribution (fleet mean 3.2 seconds).
- There was no error of omission during the roll.

- The one decision the schedule could plausibly have affected was not requesting a runway inspection. No document prompted either crew member to consider that step, so fatigue could not have caused it to be omitted.

The exposure itself is a standing one. The evening Tarlton Springs rotation routinely places the last sector inside the last hour of a 12-hour duty. The aerodrome has no company engineering, no alternate within 200 nm at night, and no crewing resilience. A single unfit crew member turns a four-sector day into a five-sector one on the morning of operation.

It is unlikely that the duty and the late running influenced the crew's actions in this occurrence, and it is likely that the schedule's built-in exposure increases risk on this route.

Individual Actions

No runway inspection requested before the first departure after last light

No runway inspection was requested before SB512 departed, and none was offered. The CVR and the tower's recorded audio contain no request, no offer and no mention of wildlife at any point before departure. The aerodrome's daily inspection log for 18/06/2026 shows one inspection, at 07:35 local before the first arrival, with the result 'movement area clear'. It shows no later inspection and no request for one. Two independent recordings and the aerodrome's own log agree, so it is virtually certain that no inspection took place.

An inspection was available for the asking. Aerodrome Manual 6.3 allows inspections outside the scheduled time when the reporting officer or a pilot in command requests one. The reporting officer confirmed that one would have been carried out if asked.

Neither crew member considered asking. No document directed them to. Part A 8.14.3 requires no specific action at an aerodrome not listed in Appendix 8A, and Tarlton Springs was not listed. The captain had expected it to be listed. The omission sat with no one: nothing prompted either crew member to request an inspection, and the aerodrome would have done one if asked. Why the listing criterion left Tarlton Springs off the list is argued under Risk Controls.

An inspection would have covered the 1,050 m to 1,250 m section, where the fence pad and both carcasses were found. Aerodrome staff disperse animals when they find them. However, an inspection some minutes before the roll cannot guarantee that the runway stays clear. Animals could have entered the strip after the vehicle had passed.

It is likely that the absence of a runway inspection before the first departure after last light contributed to the two kangaroos being on the sealed surface during the take-off roll.

Take-off rejected 6 kt above V1

The FDR shows V1 at 112 kt at 07:30:29. Both power levers were retarded to flight idle from 07:30:32 at 118 kt. That was three seconds and six knots past V1. The CVR shows the whole decision in one exchange. The first officer called "Roos - roos, roos, on the left, they're on the -" at 07:30:31, and the captain responded "Stopping. I have control." at 07:30:32. The captain's interview and air safety report confirm the decision. It is virtually certain that the take-off was rejected above V1.

Part B 4.6.4 requires the take-off to be continued at or above V1. Section 4.6 contains no guidance on an obstruction seen on the runway at any speed. It also has no amplification for a case in which continuing is itself hazardous.

The captain stated that he had weighed the alternative. In his judgement, rotating into two large animals would have left the aircraft airborne at night, with damage he could not assess, over country that offered no usable option. He chose the risk whose end he could see, and he acknowledged that the choice was outside procedure.

He made that judgement with almost no information. The first officer later said "I had them for - I don't know, two seconds. Maybe less." The captain said "I never had them. I was heads-in on the engine page after V one." The decision was therefore made on a single call, about one second after it was heard. Whether the edge lighting affected how early the animals could be seen could not be resolved, and that matter is discussed under Local Conditions. The scope of rejected take-off training is argued under Risk Controls.

The accelerate-stop margin did not allow for a late reject. The scheduled accelerate-stop distance of 1,780 m assumes the reject begins at or before V1. The margin between the distance required and the distance available was 67 m. Distance reconstruction put the aircraft 1,152 m along runway 09 when the reject began, with 695 m of sealed surface remaining. The stopping distance achieved from 118 kt was 757 m. Starting the stop six knots and three seconds late used up the 67 m margin and more, before the effect of losing No. 2 reverse is counted. That effect is argued with the strike under Occurrence Events.

It is extremely likely that rejecting the take-off 6 kt above V1 contributed to the aircraft not stopping on the sealed surface.

Maximum braking and No. 1 reverse applied without delay

The FDR shows the power levers at flight idle 0.6 seconds after the decision. Maximum braking was established at 07:30:34, 2 seconds after the decision. The operator's recorded fleet mean for rejected take-offs is 3.2 seconds from decision to maximum braking. Anti-skid was active on all four wheels throughout. Brake energy reached 84% of the certified maximum without a brake fire. No. 1 reverse was selected at 07:30:36. No. 2 reverse was unavailable because the strike had destroyed the No. 2 propeller. The first officer made the speed callouts and the runway-end call. It is virtually certain that the response was as recorded.

The aircraft left the seal at 21 kt and stopped 62 m into the 90 m RESA. It came to rest upright and on the extended centreline. Had the stop begun at the fleet mean response, the aircraft would have travelled an estimated further 30 to 40 m, close to the far edge of the RESA. The response that followed the reject was faster than the fleet average.

It is very likely that the prompt application of maximum braking and No. 1 reverse reduced the severity of the overrun, keeping it within the RESA at low speed.

Occurrence Events

Two kangaroos entered the runway strip and moved onto the sealed surface

Three independent sources each establish the animals' presence on their own. Two adult kangaroo carcasses were recovered from runway 09 at 1,188 m and 1,221 m from the threshold. The CVR captured the first officer's call at 07:30:31, "roos, on the left". The FDR recorded the impact at 07:30:33. After the aircraft stopped, the first officer described the animals: "They came out of the dark on the left of the strip, crossed the centreline." The captain stated that he had not seen them.

Where the animals came through the boundary is a separate question. The investigation found a pad through the failed northern fence at the 1,050 m mark, 138 m before the first carcass. That geometry bears on the deferred fence repair, which is analysed under Organisational Influences. It does not bear on whether the animals reached the seal.

The animals' presence was not unusual for the aerodrome. Eleven entries in the aerodrome's sighting log record kangaroos on the sealed surface of runway 09/27. No inspection had been carried out since 07:35 local that morning. The departure in the hour after last light, and the

absence of a runway inspection before it, are analysed under Local Conditions and Individual Actions.

Both the reject and the strike follow directly from the animals being on the runway.

It was virtually certain that two kangaroos entered the runway strip and moved onto the sealed surface, and extremely likely that this contributed to both the rejected take-off and the strike.

No. 2 propeller and right main gear struck two kangaroos

The recorded data, the physical damage and the recovered tissue all agree.

- The impact occurred at 07:30:33 at 114 kt, one second after the reject began.
- The FDR recorded a lateral acceleration spike of 0.31 g right and a vertical spike of 1.48 g.
- Three No. 2 propeller blades were damaged beyond repairable limits, with one blade tip separated.
- Animal tissue was recovered from two blade roots.
- The right main gear doors were distorted, and propeller debris punctured the lower right fuselage skin.

The strike's significance lies in what it removed from the stop, not in the damage itself. No. 2 propeller RPM decayed from the moment of impact, and the No. 2 reverse interlock did not make. When reverse was selected at 07:30:36, it was available on No. 1 only, and the CVR captured the captain's call, "Reverse - number two's not coming." The aircraft lost half its reverse thrust in the first seconds of a stop that, under the scheduled figures, had a margin of only 67 m.

It was virtually certain that the No. 2 propeller and right main gear struck the two kangaroos, and virtually certain that this contributed to the overrun by removing No. 2 reverse thrust for the remainder of the stop.

Deceleration achieved below the scheduled accelerate-stop performance

The scheduled figures and the achieved figures can be set side by side.

- The scheduled accelerate-stop distance required was 1,780 m against an ASDA of 1,847 m. Those figures assumed a stop begun at or before V1 with symmetric reverse.
- Neither assumption held. Distance reconstruction from recorded groundspeed placed the aircraft 1,152 m along runway 09 at the reject, at 118 kt, leaving 695 m of sealed surface.
- With reverse on No. 1 only, the mean deceleration was 2.6 m/s². This was approximately 15% below the value used in the certified accelerate-stop data for that weight and runway condition.
- The stopping distance actually achieved was 757 m. That is 62 m more than the sealed surface remaining, which matches the nose wheel rut ending 62 m into the RESA on the extended centreline.

The recorded data, the distance reconstruction and the physical marks agree. The aircraft left the seal at 21 kt, and deceleration fell to 1.9 m/s² in the gravel.

The two causal chains converge here and act as a single mechanism. The late reject, analysed under Individual Actions, set the starting speed and the remaining distance. The strike reduced the deceleration available to cover that distance. The investigation's arithmetic showed that the overrun required both contributions and that neither alone would have taken the aircraft past the runway end.

It was virtually certain that the deceleration achieved fell below the scheduled accelerate-stop performance, and virtually certain that this shortfall, combined with a stop begun 6 kt above V1, resulted in the overrun onto the RESA.

No. 2 engine power loss during the take-off roll

A No. 2 engine power loss before the reject was very unlikely and was ruled out, for four reasons:

- Both engines held 98.4% and 98.5% torque, with no caution, warning or exceedance, until the power levers were retarded at 07:30:32.
- The CVR contains no engine-related call.
- The borescope of both engines found no pre-existing damage.
- The No. 2 RPM decay began at the impact at 07:30:33, one second after the reject.

Conclusions

These findings are made with respect to the occurrence and should not be read as apportioning blame or liability to any organisation or individual.

Findings

A finding stated without a likelihood term was established as fact.

1. Under AS-139 10.4.2, a documented wildlife hazard management plan was required only above a size threshold that Tarlton Springs Aerodrome did not meet, so the aerodrome held no plan, hazard assessment or dispersal programme. This likely contributed to the occurrence by leaving the aerodrome's sighting log unconnected to the operators using it and the failed fence on an unfunded works register. This finding rests on argument rather than direct evidence: a documented plan was not the only way to repair a fence or share a sighting log, and there was no evidence that a plan would have been funded any better. (Safety issue)
2. The aerodrome operator recorded the northern perimeter fence as failed, with animals passing through, in 04/2023. It deferred the repair at the 2023, 2024 and 2025 budget rounds. This very likely contributed by leaving a 140 m breach, with an animal pad through it at the 1,050 m mark, upstream of the strike position and on the same side of the runway. (Safety issue)
3. The take-off roll very likely began in full darkness, 5 minutes after the end of civil twilight. This was within the period in which the aerodrome's own log recorded 38 of its 41 kangaroo entries. The light condition likely contributed, because the animals were not seen until they were on the lit sealed surface.
4. CMR-2025-118 approved the evening Tarlton Springs service as a schedule change only. It neither referenced nor reopened the daylight-only restriction in RRA-041 issue 3. This likely contributed, although a review might have addressed only lighting and diversion fuel, and the approver could not be asked what was considered. (Safety issue)
5. Operations Manual Part A 8.14 required a runway inspection before the first departure after last light only at aerodromes listed in Appendix 8A. The only listing criterion was a reported wildlife strike involving a company aircraft, and Tarlton Springs had never been listed. This very likely contributed by leaving the operator's own defence against this occurrence unarmed. (Safety issue)
6. No runway inspection was requested or offered before the first departure after last light, and no document prompted either crew member to consider one. It is likely that this contributed. An inspection would have covered the section where the fence pad and both carcasses were found, and aerodrome staff disperse animals when they find them. However, an inspection some minutes before the roll could not guarantee a clear runway.
7. Two kangaroos entered the runway strip from the northern side and moved onto the sealed surface of runway 09 ahead of the aircraft. This very likely contributed by prompting both the rejected take-off and the strike.
8. It is very likely that the operator's rejected take-off training covered aircraft system failures below V1 only. No external obstruction scenario was presented in the five training cycles on file. This likely contributed to the decision to reject above V1, because the captain met the question for the first time with about two seconds to decide. The evidence also supports a second reading. The captain knew the rule and departed from it deliberately, which would make the gap a finding about the fleet rather than a cause of this reject. (Safety issue)

9. The captain rejected the take-off at 118 kt, 3 seconds and 6 kt after V1, where Part B 4.6.4 required the take-off to be continued. This very likely contributed by beginning a stop that consumed the 67 m scheduled margin between ASDR and ASDA.

10. The No. 2 propeller and right main gear struck the two kangaroos at 114 kt, one second after the reject began. The strike removed reverse thrust on No. 2 early in the stop, and this contributed to the overrun.

11. The mean deceleration achieved was 2.6 m/s², approximately 15% below the certified accelerate-stop value. The aircraft needed 757 m to stop from 118 kt, with 695 m of sealed runway remaining at the reject, which resulted in the aircraft stopping 62 m into the RESA.

Other findings

12. Two of the six floor proximity escape path segments aft of row 16 on the left side were dark on battery power because of a failed common ballast. The pre-flight emergency lighting test could not detect this defect. No evacuation was commanded and the main cabin lights were on throughout, so the defect was not found to have contributed to the occurrence. It very likely increased risk to occupants in any evacuation, given a 24-month functional test interval and the same ballast fitted across the type. (Safety issue)

13. The occurrence sector was the crew's fifth, added that morning when the rostered crew reported unfit. It was flown 11 hours into the duty and 40 minutes behind schedule. The recorded data contradicted each mechanism by which fatigue could have affected this occurrence. The evening rotation's routine placement of the last sector near the end of a 12-hour duty likely increased risk.

14. A tailwind above limits was examined and ruled out. The aerodrome observations and the recorded data both gave a headwind component throughout the roll.

15. A No. 2 engine power loss during the take-off roll was examined and ruled out. Both engines were at take-off torque with no caution, warning or exceedance until the reject, and the No. 2 RPM decay began at the impact.

16. The power levers reached flight idle 0.6 seconds after the reject decision, and maximum braking was established 2 seconds after it, against a fleet mean of 3.2 seconds. This very likely reduced the severity of the outcome by keeping the overrun within the RESA.

It could not be determined whether the runway edge lighting intensity reduced the crew's ability to detect the animals, and no finding is made. The evidence was evenly balanced:

- A photometric check on 25/06/2026 measured four northern edge lights between the 900 m and 1,200 m markers at 118% to 131% of nominal for stage 3, in the section the animals crossed.
- The captain described a corridor of light with darkness either side.
- The first officer saw the animals and described the lighting as normal. She also saw them clearly once they were on the sealed surface, at about 200 m.
- The captain's non-detection is explained by his being heads-in on the engine page after V1.

No measurement exists of the lighting on the night, and nothing links an edge light at 131% of nominal to the detection of an object on the runway. Resolving the matter would require evidence of the lighting as it was on the night and of its effect on detection.

Probable cause

The runway overrun resulted from a take-off rejected 6 kt above V1 after two kangaroos moved onto the sealed surface of runway 09, which very likely began a stop the runway could not accommodate, combined with a propeller strike that removed No. 2 reverse thrust and reduced the achieved deceleration approximately 15% below the scheduled accelerate-stop performance.

Contributing factors

- The aerodrome was not required to hold a documented wildlife hazard management plan because it was below the AS-139 size threshold, which likely contributed. (Safety issue)
- The northern perimeter fence repair was deferred for three budget cycles, which very likely contributed. (Safety issue)
- The departure was made in the hour after last light, the peak of kangaroo movement, which likely contributed.
- The evening service was approved as a schedule change without the route risk assessment being reopened, which likely contributed. (Safety issue)
- The operator required a runway inspection only at listed aerodromes, and the listing criterion was a strike, which very likely contributed. (Safety issue)
- No runway inspection was requested before the first departure after last light, which likely contributed.
- Rejected take-off training covered aircraft system failures below V1 only, which likely contributed. (Safety issue)

Recommendations

Documented wildlife plan required only above a size threshold the aerodrome does not meet

Aerodrome Standard AS-139 10.4.2 requires a documented wildlife hazard management plan only where an aerodrome is used by aeroplanes above 27,000 kg MTOW or serves more than 350,000 passenger movements a year. Tarlton Springs met neither limb. Its heaviest scheduled aeroplane was 22,900 kg, and it handled 61,400 passenger movements in 2025. Under 10.4.3, its wildlife measures did not need to be documented at all. Section 10.4.1 still obliged the aerodrome operator to take reasonable measures. The aerodrome was not in breach of the standard.

The threshold matters because it left an aerodrome of this size with an undocumented and unaudited wildlife programme. The aerodrome's own sighting log held 41 kangaroo entries, 38 of them around last light and eleven on the sealed surface. That knowledge stayed in a paper register that no operator had asked to see. The failed northern fence remained on an unfunded works register through three budget cycles. The threshold likely contributed to the occurrence by leaving both without an owner or an audit trail, and it led to the deferred fence repair and to the reliance on a runway inspection listing that only a strike could trigger. This degree of confidence is lower than that attached to the other contributing factors in this occurrence.

No safety action has been recorded against this safety issue. This report makes no recommendation in respect of it.

Perimeter fence repair deferred for three budget cycles

The aerodrome operator deferred replacement of the failed northern perimeter fence at three successive budget rounds. Works register item WR-221, raised in 04/2023, described four displaced panels and strained wire between the 700 m and 1,300 m runway markers, with animals observed passing through. The repair was estimated at \$41,000. It was deferred as unfunded in 2023, 2024 and 2025, and WR-263 (02/2026) recorded further deterioration of the same section. On 23/06/2026 the investigation found a continuous 140 m failure, with the bottom two wires separated from the posts and an animal pad through the fence at the 1,050 m mark (Figure 1).

The deferral very likely contributed to the occurrence. A fence in that condition did not exclude kangaroos. The pad lay on the same side of the runway as the carcasses recovered at 1,188 m and 1,221 m, and upstream of them. It was the physical route by which the animals reached the movement area.

On 25/06/2026 the aerodrome operator installed a temporary electric wire. It funded WR-221 from the 2026 contingency and programmed replacement of the 140 m northern boundary section for 09/2026. That action was in progress when it was reported. [NOT ESTABLISHED: whether the replacement was completed as programmed in 09/2026.]

This action addresses the issue in part. It closes the breach found on site. No action has been recorded on the process under which a known fence failure, with animals observed passing through it, was deferred at three budget rounds. No recommendation has been recorded against this issue.

Evening service approved as a schedule change, route risk assessment not reopened

The operator approved a scheduled evening rotation into Tarlton Springs as a schedule change only. It was the first company operation at the aerodrome after last light. The current route risk

assessment for the aerodrome, RRA-041 issue 3, restricted operations to daylight pending review of night lighting and diversion fuel policy. The change assessment did not refer to that restriction, and RRA-041 was not reopened. The change process asked whether the change was new. It did not ask whether the existing assessment still held.

The safety significance lies in that gap. The operator's own current route risk assessment carried the restriction that should have stopped the change, and the approval placed a company aircraft at Tarlton Springs after last light in direct contradiction of it. It was likely that a review of RRA-041 against a night operation would have reached the aerodrome's wildlife exposure and the Appendix 8A listing in the same pass. Such a review might instead have dealt only with lighting and fuel, the matters the restriction names. The approver had left the company and could not be interviewed, so the reason the change was assessed this way could not be established.

Because the assessment was not reopened, a runway inspection remained required only at listed aerodromes. Tarlton Springs could be listed only after a reported strike there.

No safety action has been recorded against this safety issue.

Runway inspection required only at listed aerodromes, and the listing criterion is a strike

Operations Manual Part A 8.14.2 required the pilot in command to request a runway inspection before the first departure after last light at any aerodrome listed in Appendix 8A. It also required that the roll not commence until the result was passed. An aerodrome was listed only where a wildlife strike involving a company aircraft had been reported there in the preceding 24 months. No provision admitted an aerodrome on any other evidence, and no provision asked a crew to report a sighting. Tarlton Springs had never been listed.

The control was sound, but it could be armed only by the occurrence it existed to prevent. The aerodrome's sighting log held eleven entries of kangaroos on the sealed surface. None of them could list the aerodrome, because none was a strike and none was reported to the company.

The absence of the requirement at Tarlton Springs very likely contributed to the occurrence. Had it applied, an inspection would have been requested and a pass required before the roll, and aerodrome staff disperse animals when they find them. An inspection completed some minutes before departure would not have guaranteed a clear runway at the roll.

On 26/06/2026 the operator amended Appendix 8A by temporary revision TR-2026-04 to list Tarlton Springs. As a result, the Part A 8.14.2 requirement applies to every departure there after last light until the permanent change is made. This addresses the issue in part. It arms the control at Tarlton Springs, but the listing criterion is unchanged for every other aerodrome.

The operator should replace the Appendix 8A listing criterion so that an aerodrome is listed on wildlife exposure rather than on a reported strike. It should also add a route risk assessment trigger for any aerodrome first operated into after last light.

Rejected take-off training covers aircraft system failures below V1 only

The operator's recurrent training and its Operations Manual Part B section 4.6 prepared crews to reject a take-off only for aircraft system events. Neither addressed an obstruction on the runway at any speed. All four scripted scenarios in TRG-SYL-07 module 4 were aircraft system events: engine failure at 90 kt, engine fire at 100 kt, configuration warning at 85 kt, and engine failure at V1 plus 5 kt continued. Three arrived below V1. Part B 4.6.4 states that the take-off shall be continued at or above V1.

The issue extends beyond this crew. Over the five training cycles on file, no crew was presented with an external obstruction scenario, and the current cycle alone covers 214 crew. Both the pilot in command and the first officer independently described the same training experience. A crew that meets an obstruction at or near V1 therefore makes the decision without any briefed or practised frame. In this occurrence the captain had about two seconds. The training gap explains the conditions under which that decision was made. It does not excuse the decision.

The investigation found that this issue likely contributed to the take-off being rejected 6 kt above V1. That contribution is accepted alongside the captain's own account that he knew the rule and departed from it deliberately.

No safety action has been recorded against this issue. [NOT ESTABLISHED: any safety action taken or proposed by the operator in respect of rejected take-off training and Part B 4.6 guidance on runway obstructions.]

Cabin floor proximity emergency lighting partially unserviceable

The cabin floor proximity emergency lighting on VH-SBQ was virtually certain to have been partially unserviceable. During the disembarkation, the first officer noticed sections of the aisle floor strip unlit while walking back through the cabin. A functional check on 24/06/2026 found two of the six floor proximity escape path segments aft of row 16 on the left side dark on battery power with the system armed. The fault was traced to a failed common ballast.

It was unlikely that the defect influenced the overrun or its outcome. No evacuation was commanded, the main cabin lights were on throughout, and the disembarkation by the forward airstair took 4 minutes 8 seconds without incident.

The defect was nonetheless very likely important to safety. The pre-flight emergency lighting test on this type illuminates the ceiling lights and exit signs. It neither illuminates nor monitors the floor segments. Neither the crew nor a line engineer could have detected the failure without a dedicated functional test. The last such test was 11 months before the occurrence, within the 24-month programme interval. A fire indication, smoke or a night evacuation over the wing would have made two dark segments in the aft cabin the difference between an orderly exit and a blocked one. The same ballast is fitted across the type, and the monitoring interval cannot detect this failure. As a result, the true state of the system across the fleet is unknown.

No safety action has been recorded against this safety issue.

Distribution

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Head of Flying Operations	R. Calvert
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